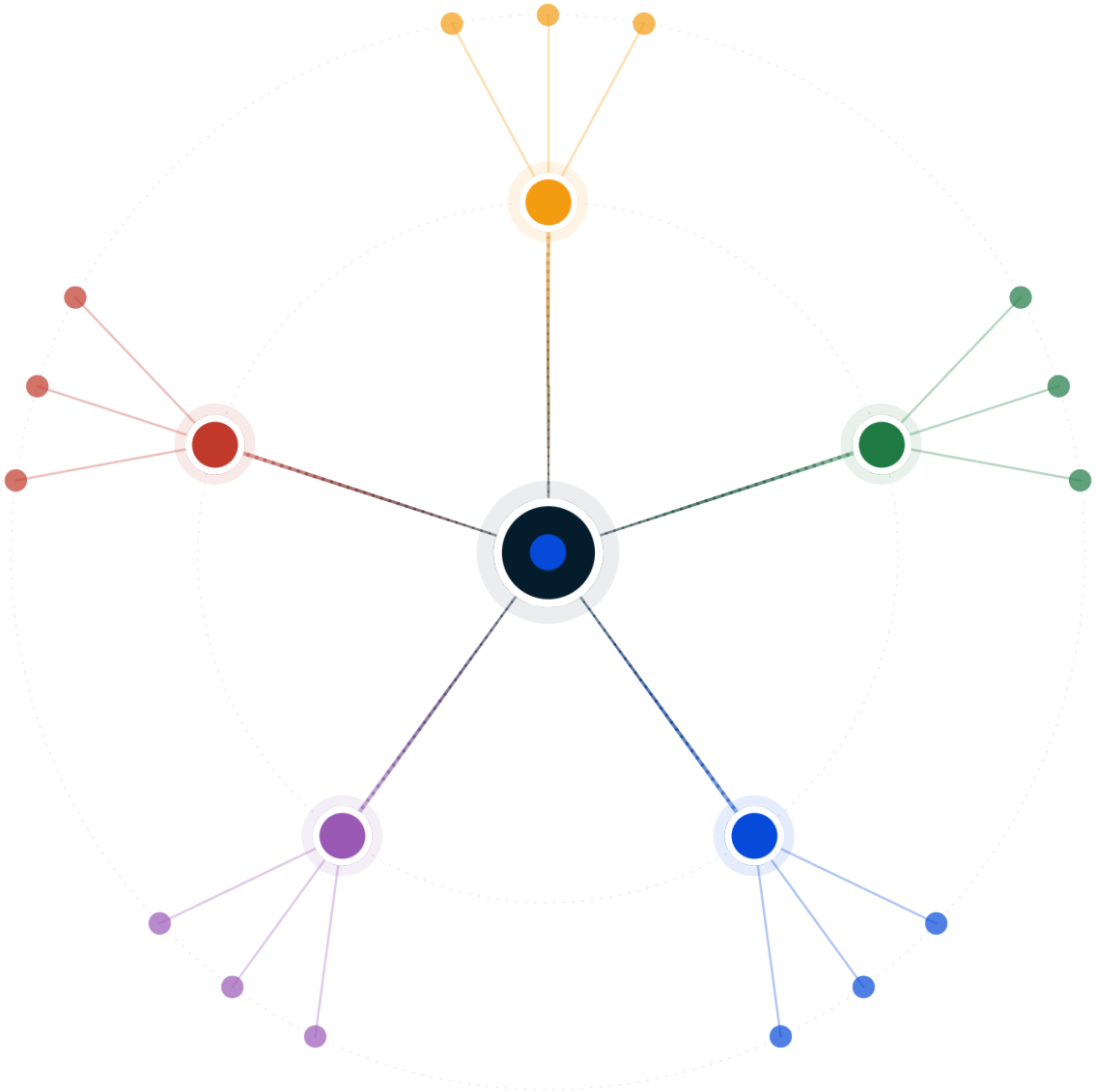
Autodecision

Should Adobe deprecate Photoshop's UI within 3 years?



Decision Brief — possibility map and recommendation

April 2026

GENERATED BY AUTODECISION — possibility map with synthesized recommendation, not a single-shot answer

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The aggressive deprecation path survives <15% of plausible scenarios; ship a segmented dual-SKU instead

Do NOT deprecate the Photoshop UI. Ship Photoshop Pro (UI + 10-year LTS) alongside Photoshop Agentic (Firefly AI Assistant native), with binding public reversal triggers.

CONFIDENCE

HIGH on do-not-deprecate · MEDIUM-HIGH on segmented+LTS structure · MEDIUM on board willingness to publish reversal triggers

DEPENDS ON

Board willing to publish binding reversal triggers · LTS commitment credible to pros · Segments are separable · Adobe execution amortizes dual-SKU R&D

MONITOR

Firefly AI Assistant beta NPS · Acrobat UI backlash trajectory · OpenAI/Anthropic creative product launches · Figma post-IPO M&A · Enterprise ELA renewal cohort

PRE-MORTEM

h6 without binding triggers (P=0.30) · Foundation model plateau (P=0.25) · Pro community rejects LTS as marketing-only (P=0.20) · Internal resourcing split degrades both SKUs (P=0.55)

DEEPEST DISAGREEMENT

Optimist: 55% first-mover platform lock compounds. Pessimist: 75% reversal-impossible franchise damage. Disagreement IS the data.

REVIEW TRIGGER

Firefly AI Assistant beta NPS <40 · OpenAI/Anthropic ships native creative · Adobe board refuses public reversal triggers · Q2 FY26 Digital Media growth <10%

Source: Decision Brief (full mode, 2 iterations, council 5/5 endorsement on h6) · [G15], [C3:council], [C4:pessimist], [C17:council]

PART 2

How we explored this decision

A 5-persona council, 6 competing hypotheses, two iterations to convergence, and 12 adversarial stress scenarios — what survived?

The analysis explored 6 hypotheses across 2 iterations of a 5-persona council, stress-tested by 12 adversarial scenarios

- 5 personas spawned as separate subagents — Optimist, Pessimist, Competitor, Regulator, Customer — each with independent context
- 6 hypotheses generated, ranging from aggressive deprecation (h1) to additive Adobe-actual strategy (h3) to the synthesis winner (h6 segmented dual-SKU + LTS + binding reversal triggers)
- 2 iterations — convergence reached at iteration 2 with 78% assumption stability, 1 productive contradiction remaining
- Adversary phase generated 12 stress scenarios across worst-cases, black swans, and irrational actors
- Sensitivity analysis on 10 key assumptions — 3 high-sensitivity, 5 medium, 2 low
- Real-time anchor: Adobe announced Firefly AI Assistant as additive on April 15, 2026 [G15] — three days before this analysis. The announced strategy is h3, the recommendation upgrades to h6.

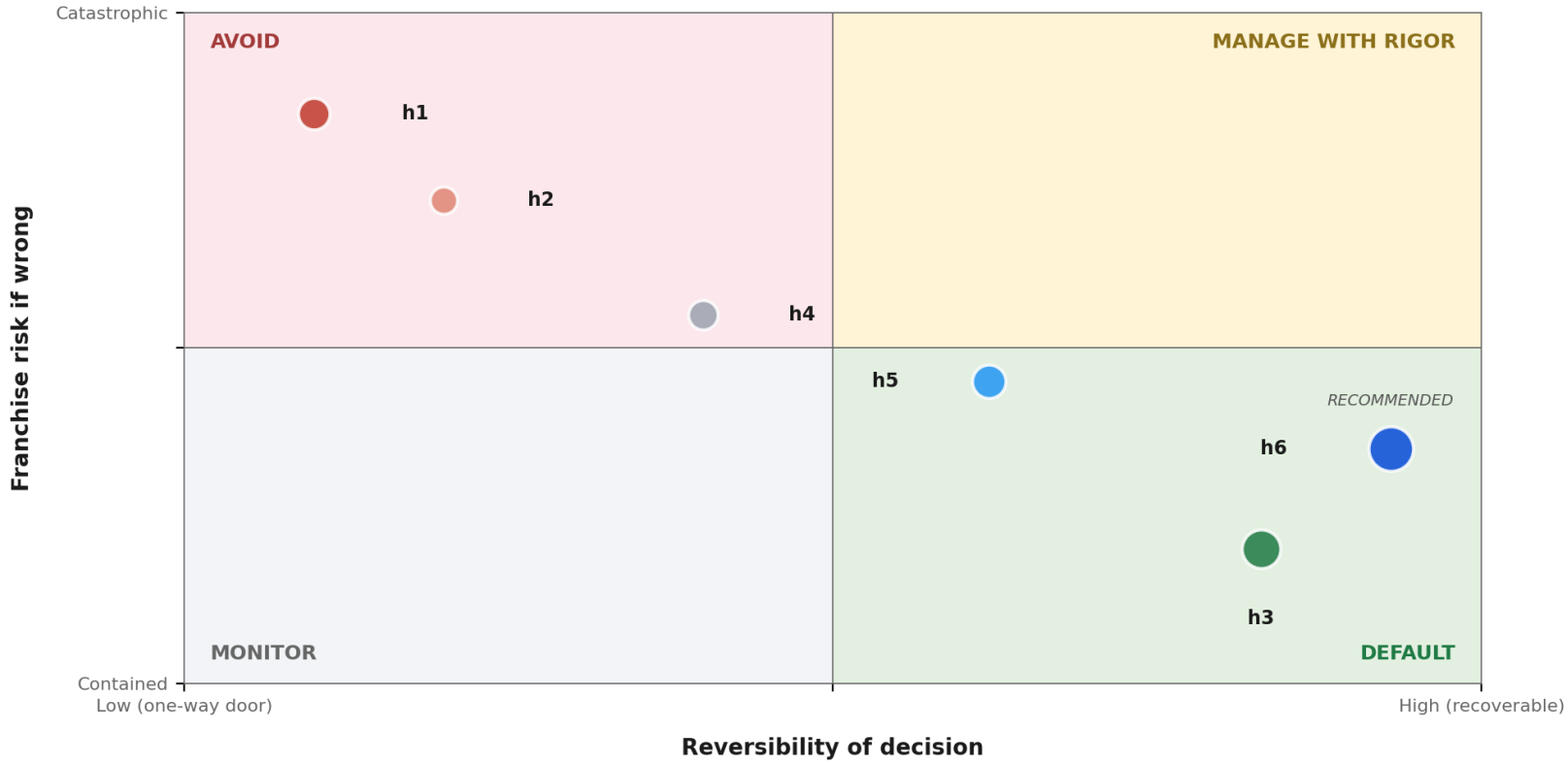
Source: Decision Brief Convergence Log; engine-protocol.md

Six hypotheses surfaced; only h6 survived 5/5 council endorsement and adversarial stress

#	Hypothesis	Status	Key assumptions
1	Aggressive deprecation wins (3-year UI sunset)	Conditional · joint P 12-20%	Agentic is terminal paradigm · 36-month parity · Foundation labs enter creative
2	User revolt destroys franchise	Risk path of h1	Muscle-memory switching cost real · Narrative damage sticky · Enterprise procurement revolts
3	Hybrid additive dominates (Adobe's actual April 2026 strategy [G15])	Strongly supported	Both modes coexist · Market rewards additive · AI Assistant quality holds
4	Competitive window closes by 2028	Conditional on foundation lab entry	Foundation labs enter creative · Category narrative matters · Translates to valuation
5	Segmentation is the right structure	Conditional on segment separability	Segments separable · Dual tier doesn't confuse · Pricing power preserved
6	Segmented + 10yr LTS + binding reversal triggers	Leading · 5/5 council	Dual SKU separable · LTS credible · Reversal triggers enforceable

Source: Decision Brief — Hypotheses Explored

Plotted on reversibility × franchise risk, h6 sits in the manageable quadrant; h1 sits where every adversarial scenario amplifies



READ

- h1 — Aggressive deprecation — irreversible, catastrophic if wrong (joint P 12-20%)
- h2 — User revolt — risk path of h1, same quadrant
- h4 — Window-closes — conditional, indeterminate position
- h5 — Segmentation — direction right, structure incomplete
- h3 — Hybrid additive — Adobe's actual April 2026 strategy [G15]
- h6 — Segmented + LTS + binding reversal triggers — captures growth while preserving optionality

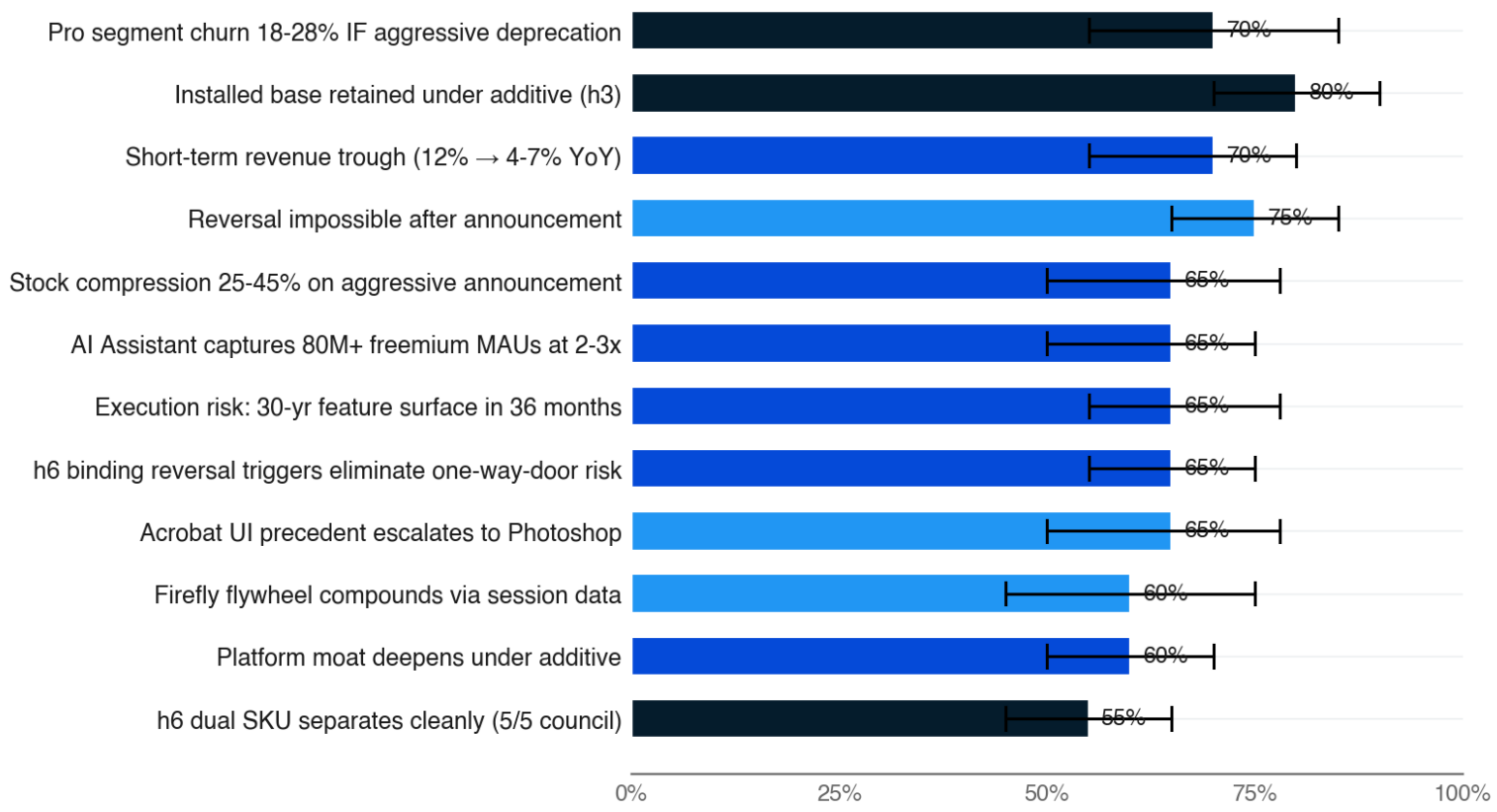
Source: Synthesis from Decision Brief — bubble size = council_agreement × probability of dominance

PART 3

What the council found

Where the personas converged, where they diverged, and what the disagreement itself reveals about the decision.

The strongest signals point to franchise risk under aggressive paths and quiet compounding under additive



- Top 12 effects ranked by council_agreement × probability
- Bar color = council agreement (navy = 5/5, fading to pale = 1/5)
- Black bracket = persona disagreement range — width is the uncertainty signal
- Two of the three highest-agreement effects (5/5) are downside under aggressive paths
- h6 effects (last row) emerge in iteration 2 with full council endorsement

Source: Decision Brief — Effects Map (top 15 by council_agreement × probability) · [C7:council], [C10:council], [C16:council]

The deepest disagreement — competitive urgency vs franchise preservation — IS the data

STRONGEST: REGULATOR (#1 PEER RANK)

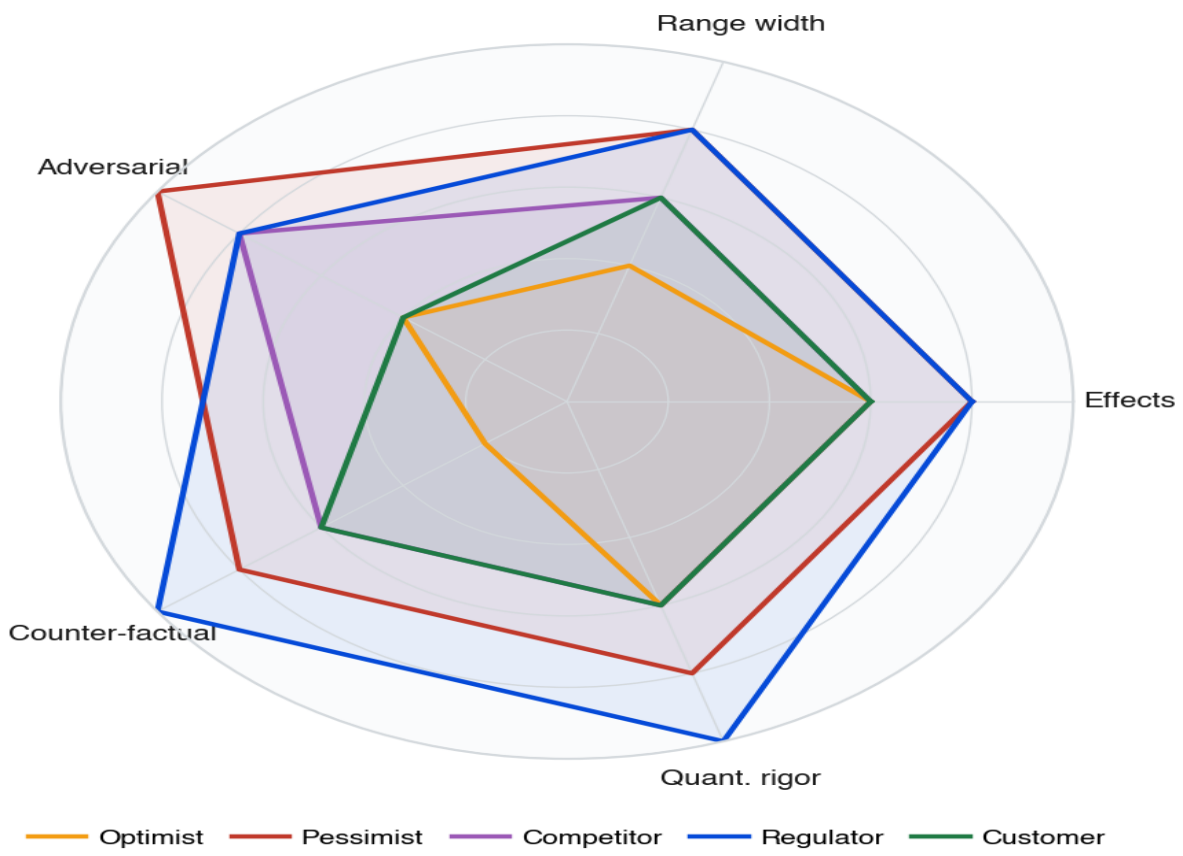
- Won on structural depth — EU AI Act obligations, Firefly training-data suit risk, fiduciary / Delaware business judgment rule, ADA Section 508 implications of chat-only UI
- Surfaced TWO of the alternatives that synthesized into h6: dual-SKU LTS + binding reversal triggers
- Identified h6 as protected under business judgment rule — reversibility insulates the board even if strategy fails
- Compliance moat (AI Act + copyright + enterprise DPA) buys 18-24 months regardless of UI strategy

DEEPEST DIVIDE: URGENCY VS PRESERVATION

- Optimist + Competitor: narrow window, first-mover lock compounds (P=0.55 [C2:optimist])
- Pessimist + Regulator + Customer: catastrophic franchise downside under forced transition (P=0.75 [C4:pessimist] reversal impossible)
- Disagreement range on foundation_labs_enter_creative: 0.30-0.70 [C3:council] — the disagreement IS the data
- Optimist was weakest (#5 peer rank) — joint-probability inflation flagged by 4/4 reviewers
- BLIND SPOT caught: 4/5 personas missed agentic inference COGS — ~10-50× per session, material at 41M subs

Source: Decision Brief — Council Dynamics · [C2:optimist], [C2:pessimist], [C3:council]

Regulator scored highest on structural depth and counter-factual rigor; Optimist's narrow ranges drove its #5 peer rank



- Each persona scored 1-5 across five rigor dimensions, derived from peer-review and critique outputs
- Regulator's structural depth surfaced both alternatives that synthesized into h6 — dual-SKU LTS and binding reversal triggers
- Optimist's narrow range and weak counter-factual depth flagged in 4/4 reviews — joint-probability inflation pattern
- Pessimist + Regulator together cover the full adversarial surface; their alignment on irreversibility risk drove the h6 design
- Customer's lower adversarial coverage is structural — the role focuses on adoption value, not threats

Source: Synthesized from Decision Brief — Council Dynamics + Critique outputs

Twelve adversarial scenarios — eight push toward kill-aggressive or segmented; only h6's reversal triggers neutralize all of them

WORST CASES

- Foundation model capabilities plateau by 2027 (P=0.25)
- Pro community organizes mass migration via plugin APIs (P=0.20)
- EU AI Act enforcement hits Firefly mid-transition (P=0.20)
- Senior ML talent departs during stock-compression trough (P=0.30)

BLACK SWANS

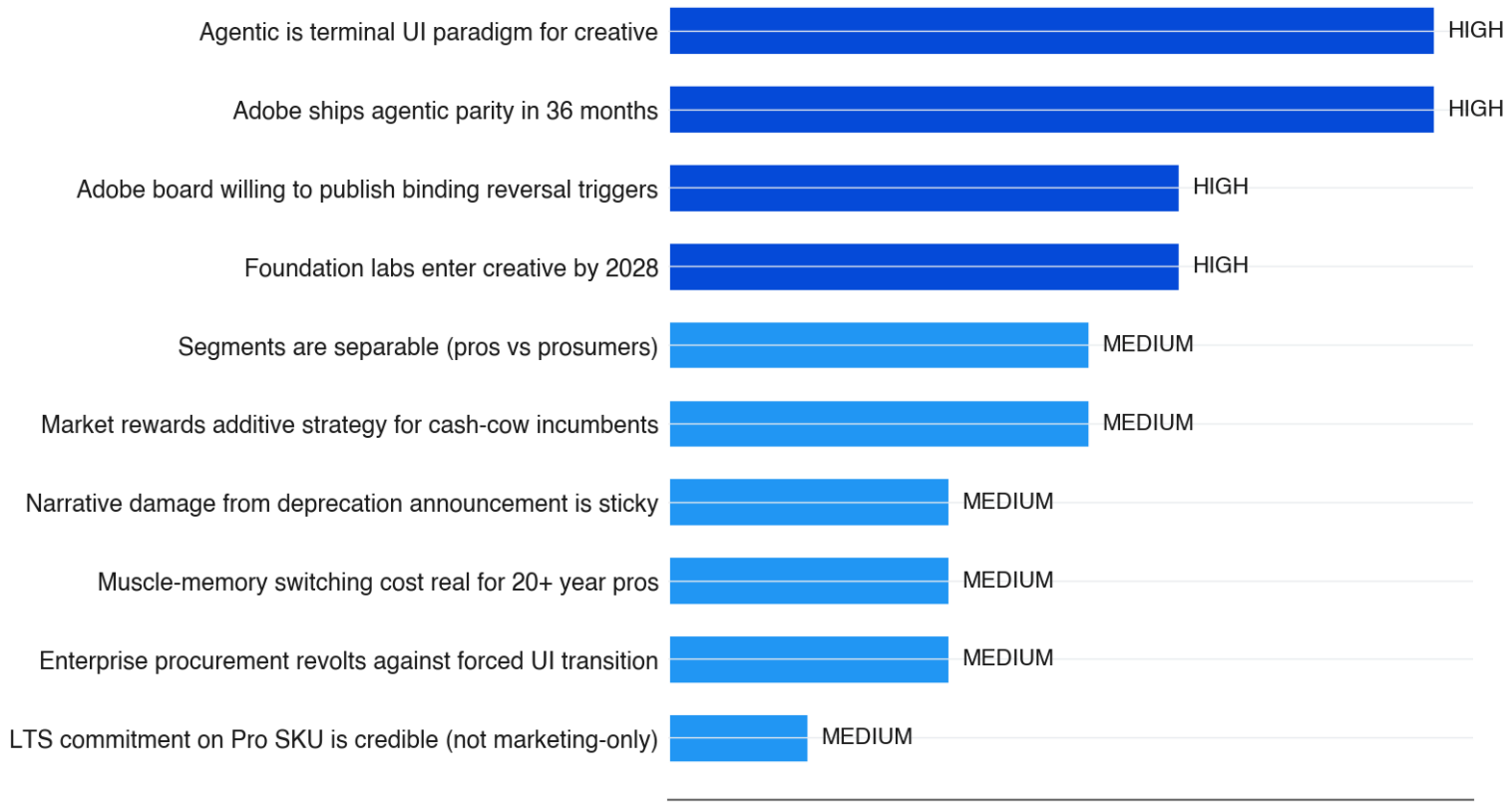
- Apple ships Vision Pro agentic Final Cut + Photos Dec 2027 (P=0.15)
- Figma acquires Runway or Midjourney with post-IPO war chest (P=0.15)
- CEO Narayen retires mid-transition; successor reverses (P=0.10)
- China bans Creative Cloud during trade escalation; $2-3B revenue (P=0.10)

IRRATIONAL ACTORS

- F500 flagship client publicly abandons Adobe; narrative contagion (P=0.15)
- Viral 'Adobe killed Photoshop' video from top creator (P=0.20)
- Activist investor takes 5% stake demanding reversal during trough (P=0.15)
- Board member leaks internal concerns; stock further compresses (P=0.08)

Source: Decision Brief — Adversarial Scenarios · [C23:adversary] through [C35:adversary]

Three high-sensitivity assumptions are load-bearing — if any one fails, aggressive deprecation becomes indefensible



- Bar length = sensitivity weight × number of effects impacted
- Dark-blue bar = HIGH sensitivity, lighter = MEDIUM
- All four HIGH-sensitivity assumptions are external — Adobe controls none directly
- h6's binding reversal triggers convert assumption-failure from catastrophic to recoverable
- If 36-month parity slips (>60% probability per [C1:council]), aggressive deprecation guarantees the partial-agentic awkward state — exactly what h6 is structured to prevent

Source: Decision Brief — Key Assumptions · sensitivity per effects-impacted × HIGH/MEDIUM/LOW weight

PART 4

Path forward

Six checkpoints with binding reversal triggers — every gate has a kill criterion before the next commitment.

The recommendation maps to a six-checkpoint roadmap with clear kill criteria at each stage

Every checkpoint has a binding reversal trigger; failure at any gate triggers either reversal or extension of LTS

When	Action	Decision point	Kill criteria
Q2 FY26	Firefly AI Assistant beta launches	Beta NPS ≥ 50 from pros	Beta NPS < 30 → reassess
Q3 FY26	Publish Pro LTS commitment + Agentic SKU roadmap	Public commitment with binding reversal triggers	Board refuses to publish → fall back to pure h3
Q4 FY26	Firefly AI Assistant GA across CC apps	GA launches on schedule	Ship slip > 2 quarters → narrative damage risk
FY27	Agentic SKU builds; Pro SKU continues UI investment	Agentic ARPU $15-20/mo; Pro maintained	Pro churn > 5% OR Agentic ARPU < $10 → reversal
FY28	Foundation lab entry decision point	OpenAI/Anthropic creative products shipped or not	Foundation lab dominant category → accelerate
FY29	3-year review point (original deprecation date)	Reaffirm LTS; evaluate market shift	Pro churn > 8% → reversal; <3% + strong agentic → continue

Source: Decision Brief — Appendix A: Decision Timeline · binding reversal triggers per [C17:council]

Selected sources

Tags appear inline throughout the deck — [G#] = ground data, [C#:persona] = council finding, [C#:adversary] = adversarial scenario

Tag	Type	Claim	Source
G2	Ground	Creative Cloud: 41M paid subs YE 2025; 80M+ freemium MAUs	prodesigntools.com, qz.com
G3	Ground	Adobe Acrobat UI redesign backlash sustained and unresolved	acrobat.uservoice.com
G15	Ground	Firefly AI Assistant announced April 15 2026 (additive, not replacement)	blog.adobe.com, news.adobe.com
G17	Ground	Firefly AI Assistant supports third-party models (Anthropic Claude)	appleinsider.com
C3	Council	Foundation labs enter creative by 2028 P=0.5 joint	iter-1 council
C4	Council	Reversal impossible P=0.75 after announcement	iter-1 pessimist
C7	Council	Pro churn spike P=0.70 with 18-28% magnitude	iter-1 council
C10	Council	Installed base retained under additive P=0.80	iter-1 council
C17	Council	Binding reversal triggers at 8% pro churn	iter-2 council
C23	Adversary	Foundation model plateau P=0.25 (worst case)	iter-1 adversary
C32	Adversary	F500 flagship client abandons Adobe P=0.15 (irrational actor)	iter-1 adversary

Source: Decision Brief — Sources (full list in companion brief markdown)